Wisdom Within

Women at the Helm of Education

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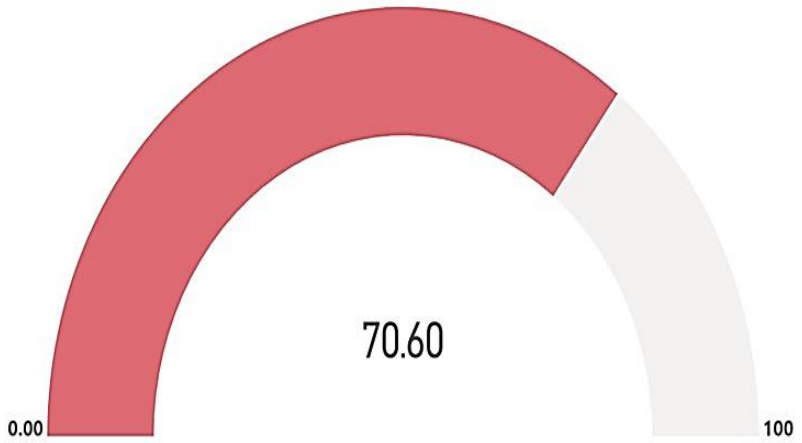
SUSTAINABLE DEVELOPMENT

- **4th** SDG goal: **Achieve inclusive** and **quality education for all**
- According to UNESCO: ***"Literacy is a continuum of learning and proficiency in reading, writing and using numbers throughout life"***

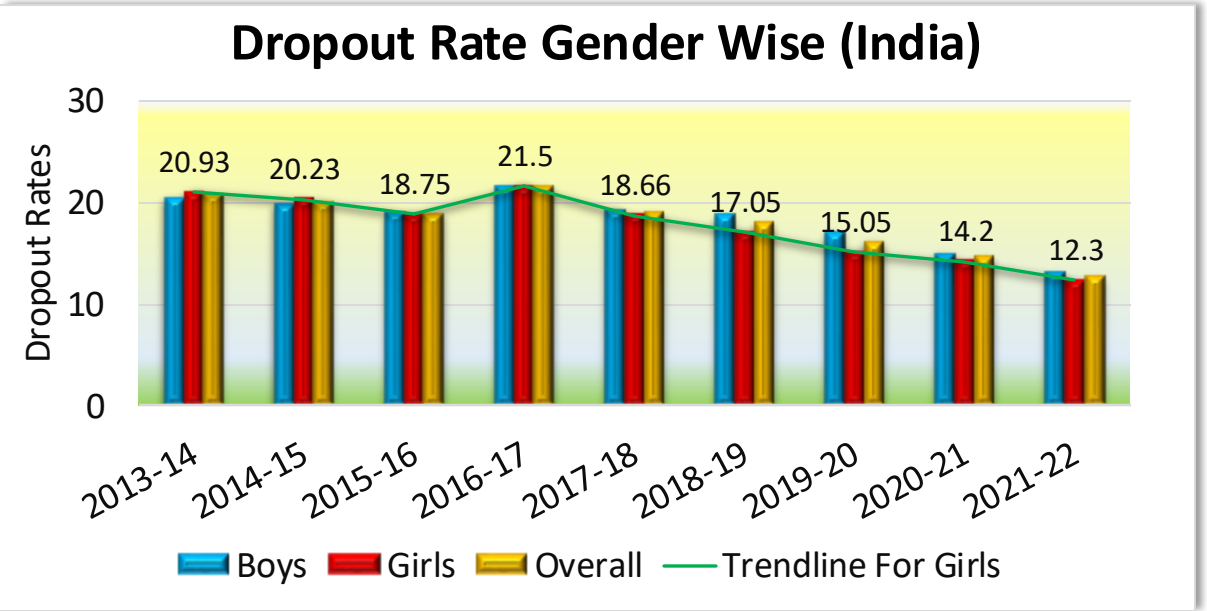


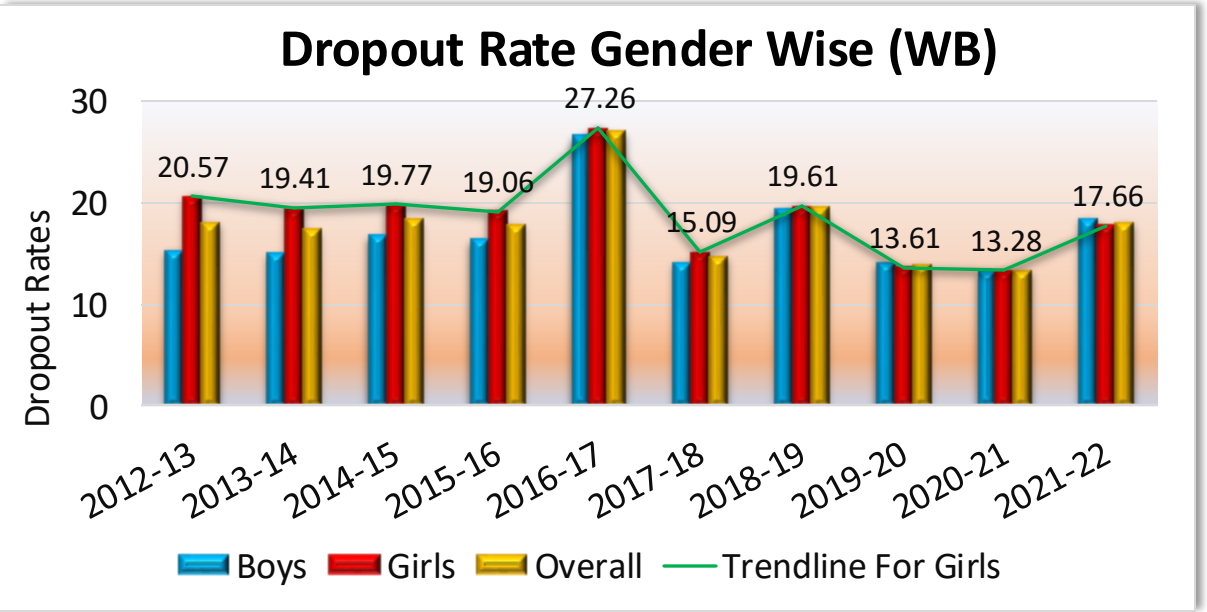
Accomplishment in terms of percentage of students in grade 3,5,8 and 10 achieving atleast a proficiency level

- **5th** SDG goal: **Achieve gender equality** and **empower all women and girls**
- The **District Primary Education Programme (1993):** Introduced to reform the schooling system and make it more **inclusive**

EDUCATION AMONG WOMEN

- Dropout rates for girls had been **higher** in the **earlier years of the millennium**
- **Demand-side factor:** Parents' perceived futility of educating girls and adherence to traditional gender roles
- Given the **high opportunity costs**, parents were reluctant to educate girls, leading to a **gender gap**
- Other reasons: stigma associated with **onset of puberty**, **absence of separate toilets** for girls and **limited number of female teachers**
- **Gender gap** in dropout rates **lower** in **WB**: Possible reasons include **poverty and pursuit of employment opportunities** (for boys) and **early marriage** (for girls)

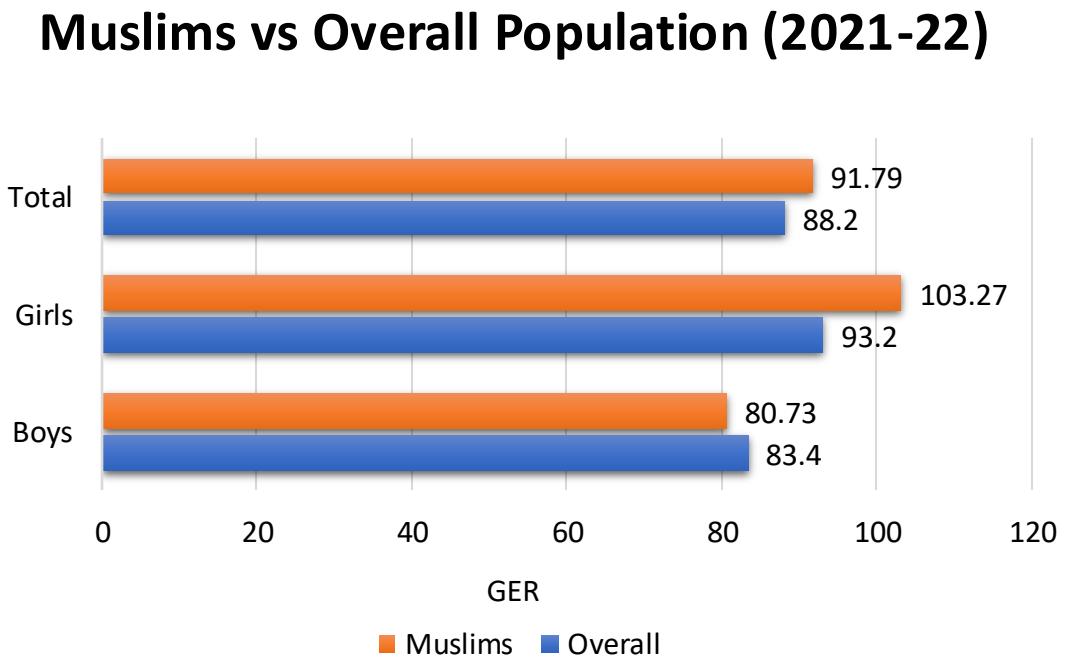




***All data based on Secondary Education*

EDUCATION AMONG WOMEN OF OTHER MINORITIES

- (In general) **Gender disparity** is **high** among socially backward groups: parents are **conservative** and do not recognise the value of girls' education
- Interestingly, Muslim parents are **skeptical about the prospects of educating their sons** for securing good jobs due to perceived discrimination
- **Higher expected benefits from educating daughters**: easier to marry off an educated daughter
- Muslim parents **do appreciate the value of education and treat girls equally**

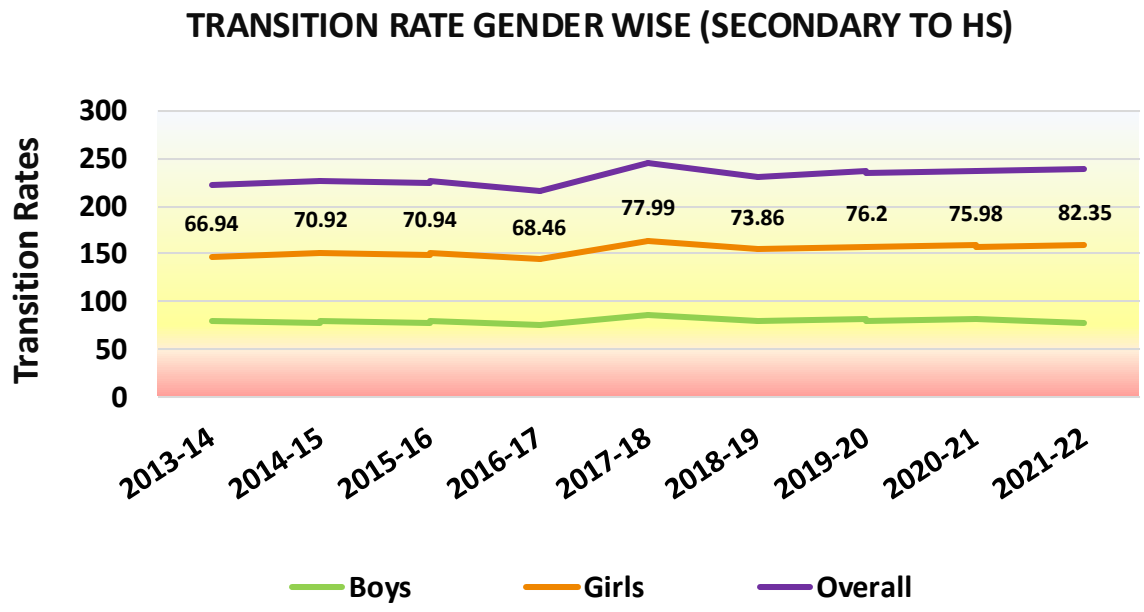


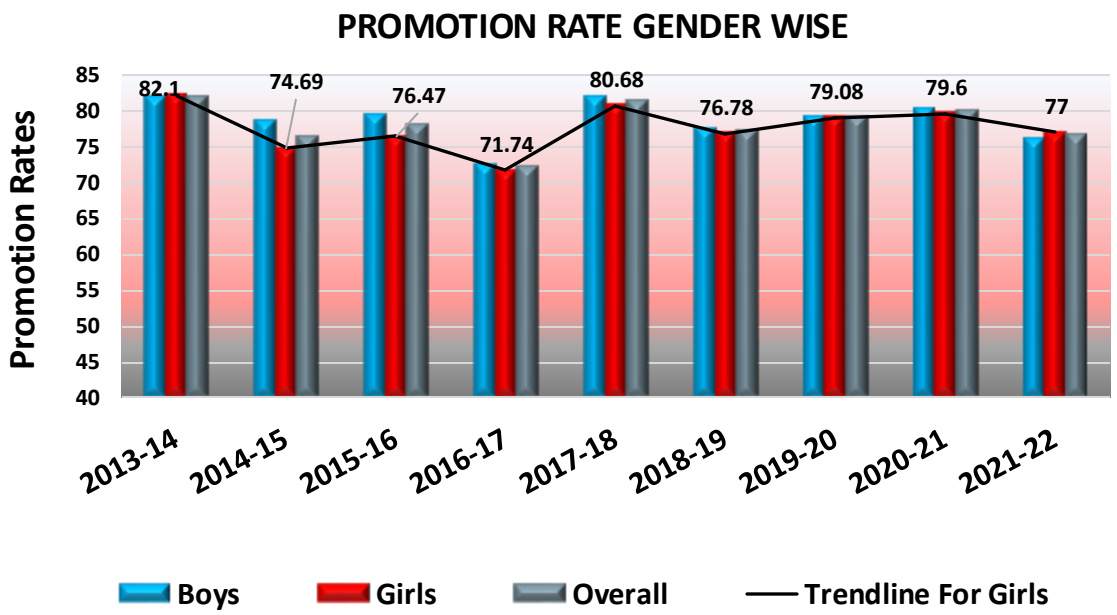
KANYASHREE PRAKALPA (2013)

Initiated by: **Government of West Bengal**

- Aim: **To elevate health, education** and **employability of girls**
- Provide an **annual scholarship of Rs.1000** and **a one time grant of Rs.25000**

REPETITION RATE			
YEAR	BOYS	GIRLS	OVERALL
2015-16	3.95	4.47	4.23
2016-17	0.92	1	0.96
2017-18	3.96	4.23	4.11
2018-19	3.26	3.61	3.45
2019-20	2.91	2.7	2.81
2020-21	6.55	7.12	6.86
2021-22	5.62	5.34	5.47



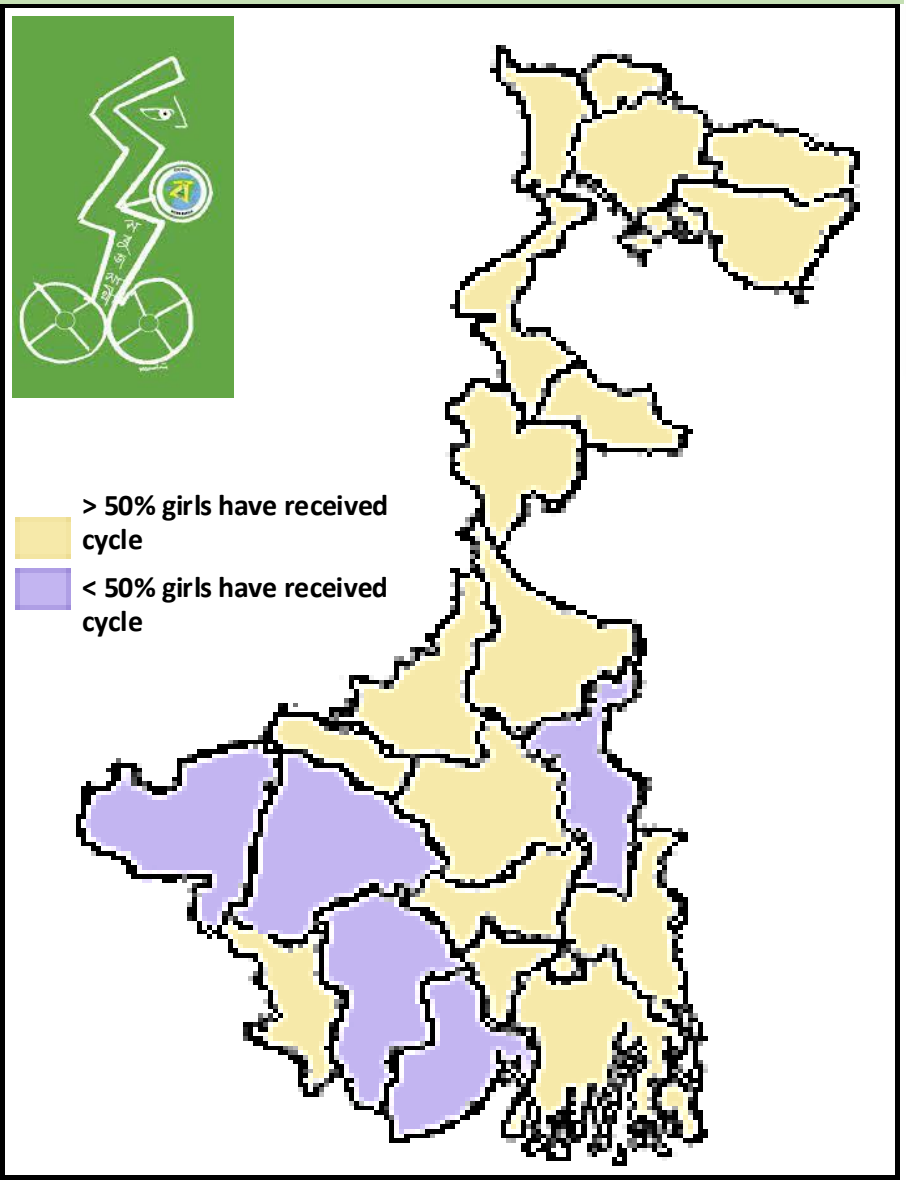


- **Increase in transition rate for girls** from 2017 onwards
- The **2020-21 pandemic** saw a **significant increase in the repetition rate** due to inadequate education

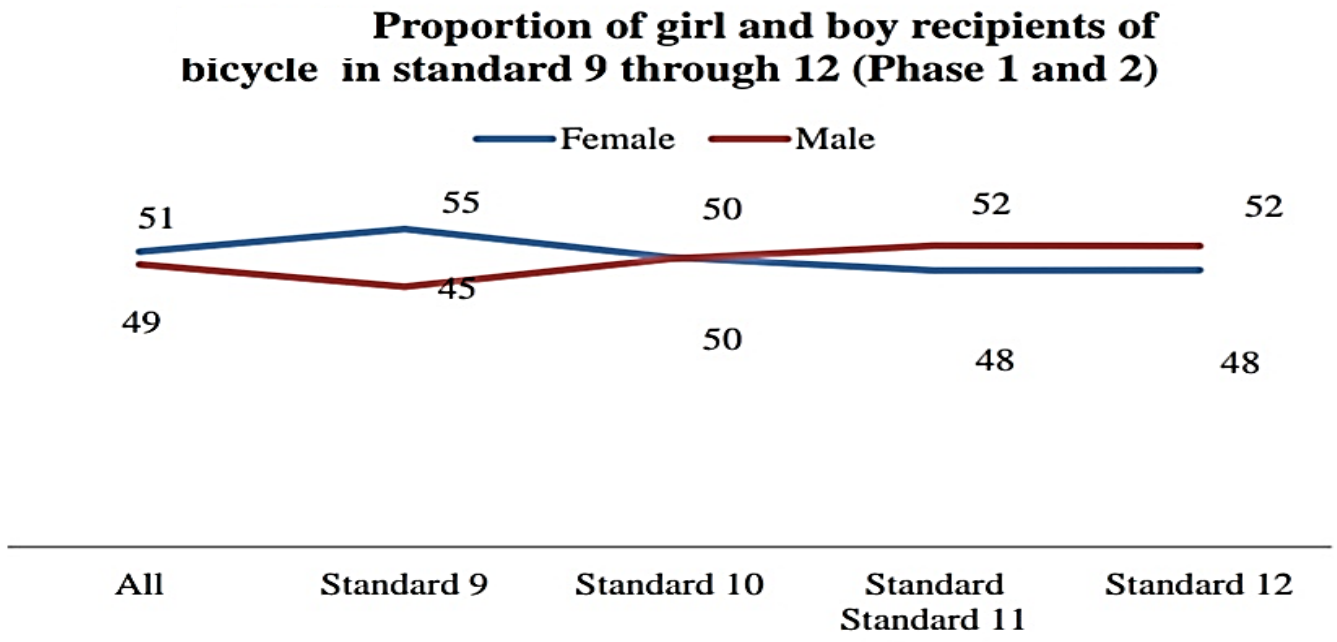
- **Significant improvement in girls' enrolment compared to boys**, indicating progress in raising awareness among society
- However, the money is often used **to meet marriage expenses**

***All data based on Secondary Education*

SABOOJ SATHI (2015)



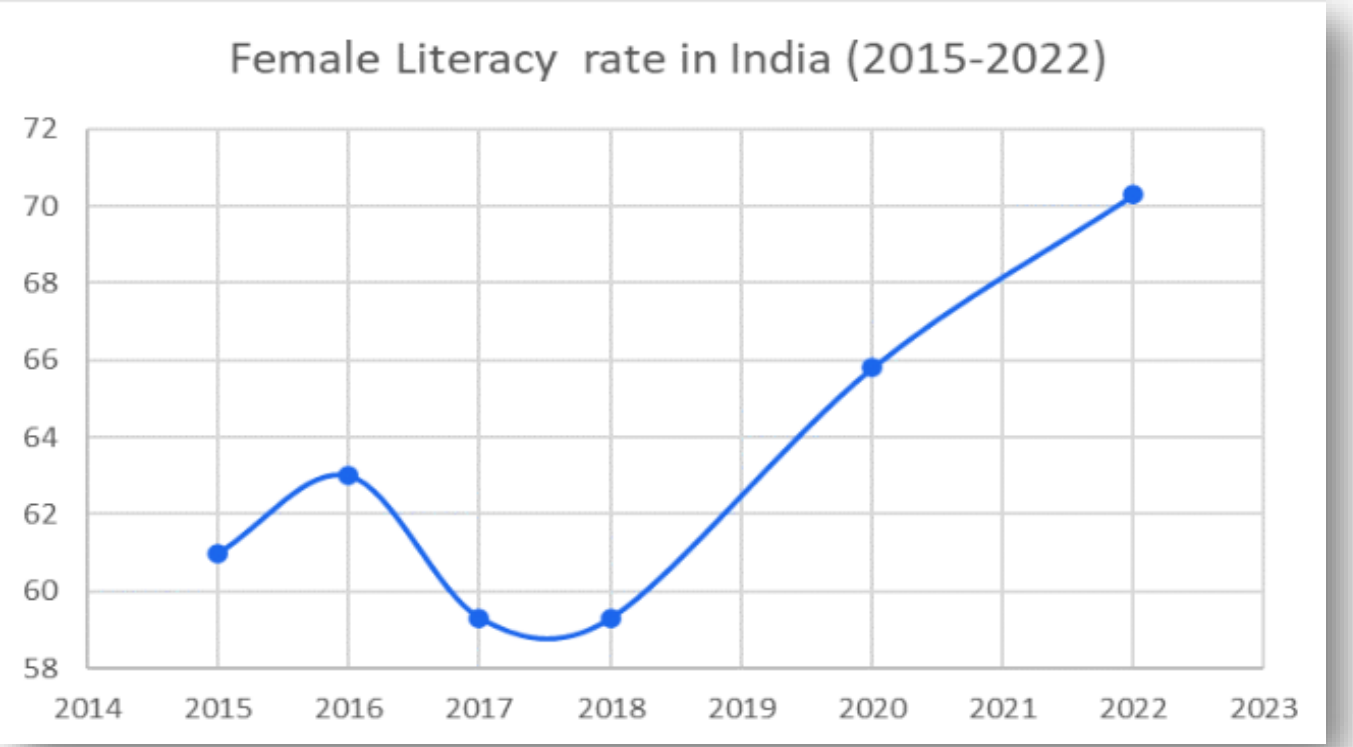
- Initiated by: **Government of West Bengal**
- **Provide bi-cycle as a mobility support to girl students** of a particular segment in the remotest region where accessibility is critical due to **difficult terrain** and **vast forest areas**
- Within two years of the experiment, it ensured **nearly 100% retention**
- While girls outnumber boys at the secondary level, the trend takes a **reverse turn** at higher secondary level



Source: Department of Backward Classes Welfare, Government of West Bengal

BETI BACHAO, BETI PADHAO (2015)

- Initiated by: The **Government of India** together with the **Ministry of Women & Child Development**, **Ministry of Health & Family Welfare** and **Ministry of Human Resources Development**
- Proactive in dealing with gender-based discrimination against the girl child: **104 districts** under initial implementation have witnessed an improving trend of **Sex Ratio at Birth**



Source: Global Gender Gap Reports (2015-2022)

- An evaluation by the **National Council of Applied Economic Research** found loopholes in the implementation process: **73.5 per cent** of schools pointed towards the dual burden of care responsibilities, unavailability of clean functional toilets, inability to buy uniforms or books and lack of safe commuting options

CONCLUSION

- Benefits of educating girls: improvement in areas of **health, nutrition, longevity, fertility** and **learning outcomes**
- **Success of government measures** in reducing school drop-outs is noteworthy
- Need to **increase awareness** about the benefits of educating girls, late marriage and increasing accessibility of schools
- Identification of appropriate means **to integrate the Muslim community with the mainstream**

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